

We are responsible for reducing the risk of the introduction of exotic pests or diseases that may affect our agricultural and horticultural industries, and our unique environment. This page provides information about importing fertiliser, to ensure that the risk of introducing an exotic pest or disease via this commodity is managed effectively.

What is fertiliser?

Fertiliser is defined as a growth enhancer, promotant or regulator that aids plant growth. Fertilisers imported into Australia can be grouped into three main groups:

- Chemical fertiliser, which is a product that is the result of a manufacturing process
- Mined fertiliser, which is a natural, non-organic product mined from the earth itself
- Organic fertiliser, which may be made of aquatic animal, terrestrial animal, avian, or microbial origin.

Why is the department interested in fertiliser?

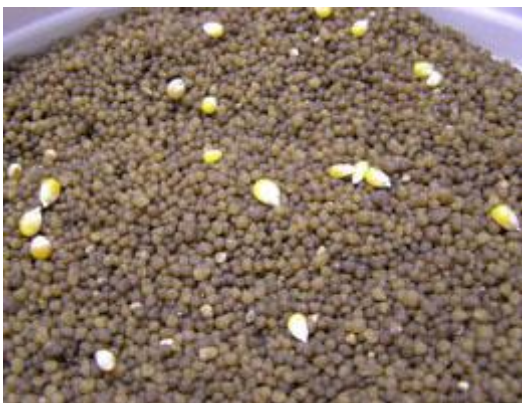
Imported fertiliser that is contaminated with soil, animal or plant based contaminants can create a pathway into Australia for exotic pests and diseases.

There is a high potential for the establishment of an exotic pest or disease as fertiliser is applied directly to soil. To address this risk, the department has developed import policies and permit conditions for importing fertiliser.

What contaminants can be found in fertiliser?

Imported consignments may be contaminated with biosecurity risk material such as:

- live insects
- seed
- soil
- plant matter (such as leaves)
- animal matter (such as faeces and feathers).



Imported fertiliser showing seed contamination



Imported fertiliser showing contamination with feathers



Imported fertiliser showing plant material contamination



Imported fertiliser showing contamination with bird faeces

Because these contaminants have the potential to introduce exotic pests and diseases into Australia, there is a legislative requirement for most importers to have specific permission to import fertiliser into Australia.

How can fertiliser be imported to Australia?

Fertiliser can be imported:

- as bulk in ship holds or containers
- in bags of less than 100kg
- in bags of 100kg or more
- samples, or
- as a liquid.

Each of these modes of importation has specific import policies, based on a risk assessment of the fertiliser pathway from the point of manufacture to arrival in Australia. The department will apply import conditions based on the potential for biosecurity contaminants to enter the fertiliser pathway.

Check if you need an import permit

For the purposes of risk management, an import permit must be obtained for goods being imported, unless they are a commodity with import conditions listed in the Biosecurity (Conditionally Non-prohibited Goods) Determination 2021.

Before importation you must search and confirm the biosecurity import conditions of your goods to determine if your item can be imported into Australia and whether an import permit is required.

For commodity requirements, please search your commodity by intended end uses in [BICON](#).

If your goods require a permit, an import permit will need to be approved prior to the import of goods. If the department is unable to grant an import permit as the goods do not meet Australia's [appropriate level of protection](#) or the manufacturer has not provided sufficient information, the goods cannot be imported.

Goods requiring a permit that arrive without a permit may be re-exported or destroyed at the importers expense.

Production questionnaires

Animal consumption and environmental purposes

To import goods for industrial or environmental purposes, you will need to ask relevant persons to complete our questionnaires. You will then need to submit the questionnaire as part of your import permit application in the BICON system.

All facilities that manufacture or export your product need to complete the animal consumption and environmental purposes production questionnaire . The facility must complete the form within 6 months of your application.

Microalgae

If your product contains microalgae, relevant parties need to complete the microalgae questionnaire. The facility must complete the form within 6 months of your application.

Manufacturers may either complete the microalgae questionnaire or the animal consumption and environmental purposes production questionnaire.

Third-party facility questionnaire

What happens when fertiliser lands in Australia?

The department inspects the fertiliser when it lands in Australia. This inspection must take place either in the vessel hold or at a registered Approved Arrangements site . Charges apply for this service.

Before applying for an import permit, prospective importers need to ensure that they have arranged for the fertiliser to be unpacked or stored at one or more Approved Arrangement site in each port of discharge if needed. The approved arrangement sites need to be of appropriate classification to receive fertiliser and need the storage capacity to handle the volume of product being imported.

What are my responsibilities as an importer?

Importers are asked to ensure quality control systems are in place offshore from the point of manufacture through to the point of importation in Australia and during handling and storage of the product. These systems must eliminate the potential for contamination to enter the fertiliser pathway.

To expedite the biosecurity clearance process, it is in the importer's interest to ensure that consignments are free from biosecurity risk material.

What happens if the consignment is contaminated with biosecurity risk material?

If contaminants that are quarantine risks are detected in consignments, further action will be necessary.

This action is undertaken at the importer's expense.

It is a condition of importing fertiliser that each consignment must be free of any biosecurity risk material before arrival in Australian territory. Consignments arriving with any form of contamination are deemed to be non-compliant to import conditions. Compliance strategies and activities will be carried out in accordance with [whole-of-department Compliance Policy](#).

Where do I find further information?

- [Importing chemical and mined fertiliser, including the department's inspection policies](#)

- [Importing organic fertiliser](#)
- [Use BICON for more information about importing other types of fertiliser.](#)

Contact us

If you require further information please contact the Client Contact Group - Canberra:

Phone: 1800 900 090

Email: [Imports](#)

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/import/goods/fertiliser>